



Epic battle: Frances Tiafoe's promising run ended in a thrilling four-set semifinal against fellow American Shelton. AP

showdown started way too late at 11:10 pm, and for 4 hours and 28 minutes, the two consummate athletes mesmerised spectators with dazzling shots, sometimes three, four or even five during the same point. Rapid-fire net duels, acrobatic overheads, outrageous passing shots on the dead run, feathery drop volleys, topspin lob winners and seemingly impossible gets produced rousing ovations and alternating chants of "Let's go, Carlos!" and "Let's go, Ben!"

A 10-point match tie-break fittingly climaxed the late-night show. At 9-7, match point, the still-energetic Shelton leaped up and banged a 146-mph ace, and the valiant competitors received a prolonged standing ovation. Nearly all the spectators had stayed until 3:33 am., the latest US Open finish ever, also fittingly, in 'the city that never sleeps'.

In a sporting gesture, Shelton and Alcaraz enjoyed a long embrace at the net, with the loser flashing a broad smile. "This was a war, an epic match," said the ecstatic Shelton.

Shelton's semifinal opponent, the extroverted Tiafoe, benefited from a relatively easy draw that opened further when Mariano Navone, a 25-year-old clay-court grinder from Argentina, upset Djokovic, one of his boyhood idols, 7-6(5), 5-7, 4-6, 6-2, 6-1 in a first-round shocker.

Djokovic fired three aces in the opening game and led 4-3 but was already struggling physically. Like an ageing boxing champion who had taken too many punches, Djokovic was a shadow of the giant that amassed a record 24 Grand Slam titles. He received a back rub following the fourth set, but after losing the first point of the deciding set, he bent over in pain and grimaced. Serving in the mid-90-mph range, he meekly succumbed.

In another first-round battle, Tiafoe barely survived against Martin Damm. The 6ft 8in American lefty, ranked a misleading No. 98, upset 2021 US Open champion Daniil Medvedev a week earlier. Against Tiafoe, he smacked huge serves and hit shots from inside his baseline more than 30 per cent of the time to rush opponents. The more experienced and versatile Tiafoe took his best punches and eventually prevailed 6-4, 4-6, 3-6, 6-3, 6-4.

'Big Foe' overcame another tough foe in the quarterfinals. Alex

Michelsen, overshadowed by the bumper crop of talented newcomers like Fils, Fonseca and Tien at the 2024 Next Gen tournament, said: "I feel I'm not too far from them. I'm just one good week from catching up." The 22-year-old Californian backed up those confident words with straight-set wins over 16th-seeded Brandon Nakashima and 27th-seeded Tomas Martin Etcheverry.

Michelsen started hitting backhands off the garage door when he was three, and at age six told his tennis-playing parents: "If you want me to play lefty, I'll quit tennis." Fortunately, Alex didn't and developed an exceptional backhand and a first serve so potent that 36 per cent of them weren't returned in his previous four matches.

With the underdog-loving crowd firing him up, Michelsen had Tiafoe on the ropes. He served for the match at 7-5, 6-3, 5-3. And then, in the biggest game of his young career, he choked! Two double faults. Then two backhand errors. Just like that, the momentum switched completely. "It's amazing how 10 days of clarity can become cloudy in 10 minutes," said ESPN analyst Andy Roddick.

Tiafoe went on to a dramatic 5-7, 3-6, 7-5, 6-3, 7-6(10-6) victory. Seconds later, in the Open's most poignant moment, the two warriors embraced at the net and Michelsen sobbed uncontrollably on Tiafoe's shoulder. "I know how much it hurts," Tiafoe told him. The heartbroken loser walked off the court with a towel covering his face. "He was a great guy for consoling me at that moment," Michelsen said later.

Arthur Ashe, the first Black men's champion at a Grand Slam event, the 1968 US Open, and the last Black finalist here in 1972, would have beamed with pride at the first all-Black men's semifinal at a Major, especially an all-American one. In 1988, Ashe famously said, "Given the same chance others have had, blacks could dominate tennis in as little as 10 to 15 years just as they have dominated in other sports." He never